

Racing Robots

The Defense and Advanced Research Projects Agency (DARPA) is organising a robot car race in the desert outside Las Vegas. The 150-mile desert course will test the skills of the machines along mountain switchbacks, gullies, dry lake beds, tunnels and manmade obstacles.



An Underwater Cable System

NEC Corporation has signed a contract with Bharat Sanchar Nigam Limited (BSNL) and Sri Lanka Telecom (SLT) to provide a submarine cable system which help provide broadband network to both countries. The Bharat Lanka Cable System is expected to be completed in the second quarter of 2006.



Enter

Shreyas Talpade
Actor

A well-known face on TV, actor Shreyas Talpade has hit the big league with his performance in *Iqbal*. From his comic role in the popular Marathi play *All The Best* to *Iqbal* and onward, Talpade is keen on new avenues in acting. Here are his views on technology.

What does technology mean to you?

I think technology makes life much simpler, easier and better.

How do you use technology in your daily activities?

In this day and age you cannot be oblivious to technology. There are new innovations frequently taking place. My day starts with the morning alarm on my mobile, which I think is one of the finest technological inventions. I also surf the Internet, check e-mails and generally read up. I largely resort to Wikipedia and Google for information.

What gadgets do you own?

I have a cell phone and a PC. I am very interested in still photography, and I have a Sony HC 40E camera.

How has technology influenced your career?

It's due to technology that my performances have reached a wide audience. Had it not been for the medium of cinema, my work would not have received the same recognition. The post production tools help us enhance our work before it is delivered to viewers. Technology is an integral part of my career!

CONSTANT INNOVATION

It's A Google-Mad World

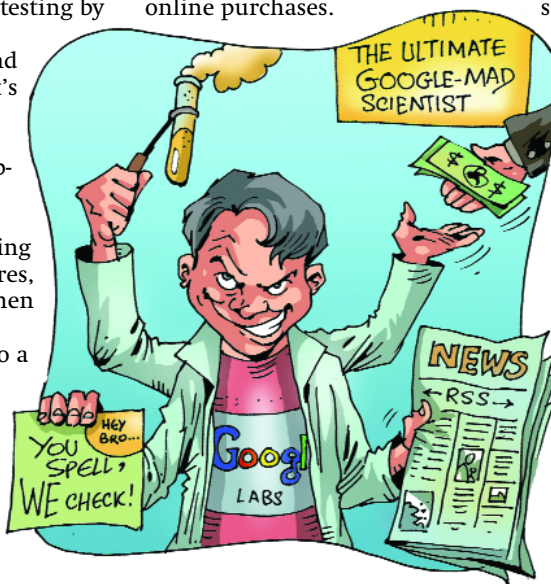
Almost every second day we see something related to Google in the news: first it's Photoshop experts fooling the world into believing that Google's "Internet OS" is already in Beta testing by sending fake screenshots around the world. Then it's Google-crazy bloggers testing every URL and sub-domain combination of google.com, hunting for any new features, getting excited when one such sub-domain resolves to a different error page than is considered normal!

Yes, it's a Google world, and the company's popularity is on the up. However, it's not just all rumours. Google really is doing a lot to put out some great new features and tools.

Recently, Google's 'robot.txt' file was updated to reflect some new directories: /gwt and /purchases. Basically, a robots.txt file tells search engine bots where they can and cannot navigate in a directory structure. Since you do not need to add directories that do not exist, the fact that Google added these directories to their own robots.txt file tells us that these directories

indeed exist, and search bots are not allowed in!

This, say Google-fans, is damning evidence that "Google Wallet" is almost here. What's Google Wallet? Think PayPal, think of online purchases.



Google has not had anything to do with this lucrative section of the Internet thus far, and it's only obvious that sooner or later, they will. Changes to the 'robot.txt' file suggest that this change is already in the pipeline.

Google also recently launched their Google Reader, which is a simple RSS reader. The difference is that instead of residing in your system tray, this reader is online. All you need is a Google account to get access, add your favourite RSS feeds, and then access your news from any Internet connection in the world.

There's also another unpublished feature that fans have stumbled across: www.google.com/webhp?complete=1&hl=en/. What? Basically, Google is testing a feature that will suggest search terms as you type, and even give you the approximate search results available for that particular search term. Take a look at the site to better understand what we mean.

So that's an online feed reader, a spell checker, and a rumoured "wallet" solution all happening in a short span of time. Looks like Google Labs is working full steam to revolutionise every aspect of our lives on the Net.

We're not complaining now, are we?

XP STARTER EDITION

A Cheaper Windows... Does India Care?

With hardware prices falling left, right and centre, it was only a matter of time before Microsoft paid heed to all the unsatisfied muttering happening in this part of